PORTFOLIO · OCTOBER 2026

Scan. Model. Decipher.

Making hidden structure visible.

Théo Alessandro Hermann

Roboticist and urban scientist · MIT Senseable City Lab Rio

thermann.ai@gmail.com · theoalessandro.com · theohermann.ch · github.com/thrmnn · linkedin.com/in/theohermann-epfl

ABOUT

I'm Théo, a French-Brazilian roboticist and urban scientist. Paris, São Paulo, Rio, Lausanne, Amsterdam, Barcelona, Stockholm.

I trained in robotics at EPFL, built perception for a person-following robot at VITA Lab and for an autonomous boat at Roboat, then brought the same tools to cities at MIT Senseable City Lab.

Wherever I work, the question is the same: what aren't we seeing yet that explains how the system behaves? Today I help robot makers find out why their systems fail, and I study how city form shapes light and air.

Speaking Dubai Future Week, 18–21 Nov 2026

PRACTICE · 2026

Making autonomous systems legible

Hidden	Robot failures the logs don't explain.
Revealed	The real cause, found and proved independently.
Changed	Evidence a team can act on, and that its safety assessors will ask for from 2027.

theohermann.ch

IN THIS PORTFOLIO

Camera perception for canal boats Roboat, MIT spinoff · first intern, 2024 3

How city form shapes light and air MIT Senseable City Lab Rio · since 2025 4

Leaf area from an aerial scan Senseable City Lab, MIT and AMS Institute · since 2024 5

Finding the moment a robot got lost Open source · 2026 6

Autonomous mobile robot navigation on a Segway Loomo EPFL VITA Lab · 2022–23 8

A real-time vision pipeline Open source · 2026 9

Event cameras for high-speed drone state estimation IRI (CSIC-UPC, Barcelona) · 2023–24 11

A street-level sensor anyone can build MIT Senseable City Lab Rio · Octopus 12

A harness for AI agents Open source · 2026 13

Roboat, MIT spinoff · first intern, 2024

Camera perception for canal boats

Computer vision and MLOps intern, the first · Amsterdam · March to August 2024

Hidden	An autonomous boat that read the canals through LiDAR alone.
Revealed	Camera detection and tracking, running on the boat's own edge computer.
Changed	A second sense on board, and every model traceable to the recordings it learned from.

THE PROBLEM

Roboat's autonomy already worked, and it worked on LiDAR. LiDAR is precise and expensive, and on water it reports a great deal that is not an obstacle: reflection, wake, chop. The open question when I arrived was how much of the perception job a camera could take on instead, on hardware that fits on a small vessel and inside a real-time budget.

WHAT I DID

I joined as the first intern and built the camera side of the stack: detection and multi-object tracking running on the vessel's own edge hardware, trained on the recordings the boats had been collecting from the canals. Water is an awkward subject for a detector, because the same object looks different under glare, reflection and weather, and the things you most need to catch are the things you have least footage of.

The second half of the work was the part that outlives any particular model. Datasets and model versions went under DVC so a result could be traced back to the exact data that produced it, and retraining stopped being a thing one person could do on one laptop.

WHAT IS NOT HERE

The performance figures belong to Roboat and are not mine to publish.

Object Detection · Multi-Object Tracking · PyTorch · YOLO · ROS 2 · Jetson Orin · Edge Deployment

theoalessandro.com/projects/autonomous-boat-perception

MIT Senseable City Lab Rio · since 2025

How city form shapes light and air

Research fellow since January 2025, there from the Rio branch's first week

Hidden	How light and air move through a city built without plans, which measures made for street grids miss.
Revealed	3D models of the fabric, from the whole city down to a single alley, to study sunlight and airflow where people live.
Changed	Measures that hold on a fabric the standard ones were not built for. The findings stay with the papers until they are out.



THE PROBLEM

Most ways of describing a city assume that someone drew it first: streets with names, plots with edges, blocks that repeat. Informal settlements are not built that way, so the standard descriptors either fail outright or quietly measure the wrong thing. Anything you want to say afterwards about how air, light or heat move through that fabric depends on describing its geometry first.

WHAT I BUILD

A Python pipeline that turns building footprints and a digital terrain model into a grid of morphometric indicators, fine enough that a single alley is resolved rather than averaged away. The indicators are the standard vocabulary of urban physics, computed so they hold on a fabric they were not designed for: sky openness, frontal area density, height variation, slope, aspect, porosity.

On top of that sits a sampling design that decides where a computational fluid dynamics campaign should actually look, rather than simulating everywhere at uniform cost, and an ingestion layer that turns public meteorological records into the boundary conditions those simulations need. The simulations themselves run elsewhere; this work defines what they receive and how their output is read back.

WHAT IS SHOWN HERE

The geometry of one site, Vidigal, is drawn on theoalessandro.com. Nothing else from this work appears here. It is unpublished research with co-authors, so this page describes the method and stops there: no indicators, no findings, no figures from the study.

HOW IT WORKS

1. Clip the building footprints and terrain model to each site, then compute each indicator on its own: sky view, solar access, sectional porosity, occupancy density, urban form.
2. Stratify the fabric on sky view, slope and built density to choose where airflow is simulated (OpenFOAM, on MIT's cluster, in a separate pipeline).
3. Weight the results by the site's wind rose, built from public weather-station records.

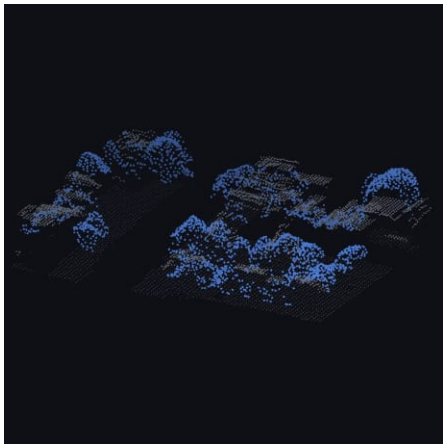
Urban morphometrics · Point clouds · LiDAR · Terrain models · Python

theoalessandro.com/projects/urban-morphometrics

Senseable City Lab, MIT and AMS Institute · since 2024

Leaf area from an aerial scan

Hidden	How much leaf a city's trees carry. Registers record where each tree stands, not how much shade it gives.
Revealed	Leaf area per tree, recovered by a physical inversion from the aerial LiDAR survey the city already flies.
Changed	An estimate that can be argued with on its own terms, from data that already exists. The numbers stay with the paper until it is out.



THE PROBLEM

Municipal tree registers are good at the things a register is for: species, location, trunk diameter, when it was last inspected. They do not record how much leaf a tree actually carries, which is the quantity that matters for shade, cooling and interception. Measuring it directly, tree by tree, across a city is not something anyone is going to fund.

WHAT I BUILD

Cities already fly aerial LiDAR surveys on a regular cycle for entirely unrelated reasons. Those scans contain the information: a pulse that passes through a canopy and a pulse that is intercepted by it are distinguishable, so the fraction of sky visible through the crown can be recovered from data that already exists.

From that gap fraction, leaf area follows by a physical inversion rather than a fitted model, which is the part I care about most. The relationship between how much light a canopy blocks and how much leaf it carries is classical physics with known assumptions, so the estimate can be argued about on its own terms instead of defended as the output of a regressor nobody can inspect. An earlier version of this work did use machine learning; the current method does not.

WHAT IS SHOWN HERE

Nothing but the method. This is a multi-author manuscript in preparation, so there are no numbers, figures or findings on this page, and there will not be until it is published.

Remote sensing · LiDAR · Canopy · Beer-Lambert inversion · Python

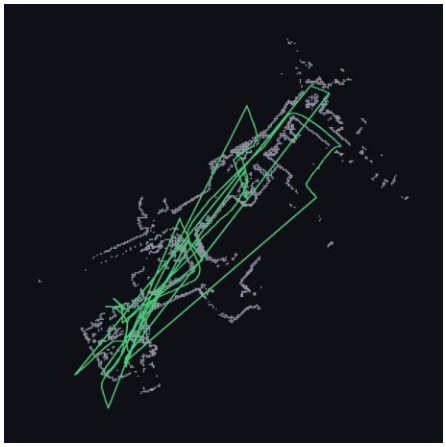
theoalessandro.com/projects/aerial-lidar-tree-census

Open source · 2026

Finding the moment a robot got lost

Mine end to end: I recorded the faults, ran the tool and graded the results myself

Hidden	Robots that lose track of where they are while still reporting high confidence.
Revealed	Four detectors that find those moments in the logs a fleet already records, run unchanged on recordings from five platforms.
Changed	Published with what it missed, and nearly every number recomputes from the repository with one script.



Method public: github.com/thrmnn/ros2-localization-triage

PROBLEM

A robot misbehaves at a customer site and someone has to comb the bag files and logs to find out why.

BUILT

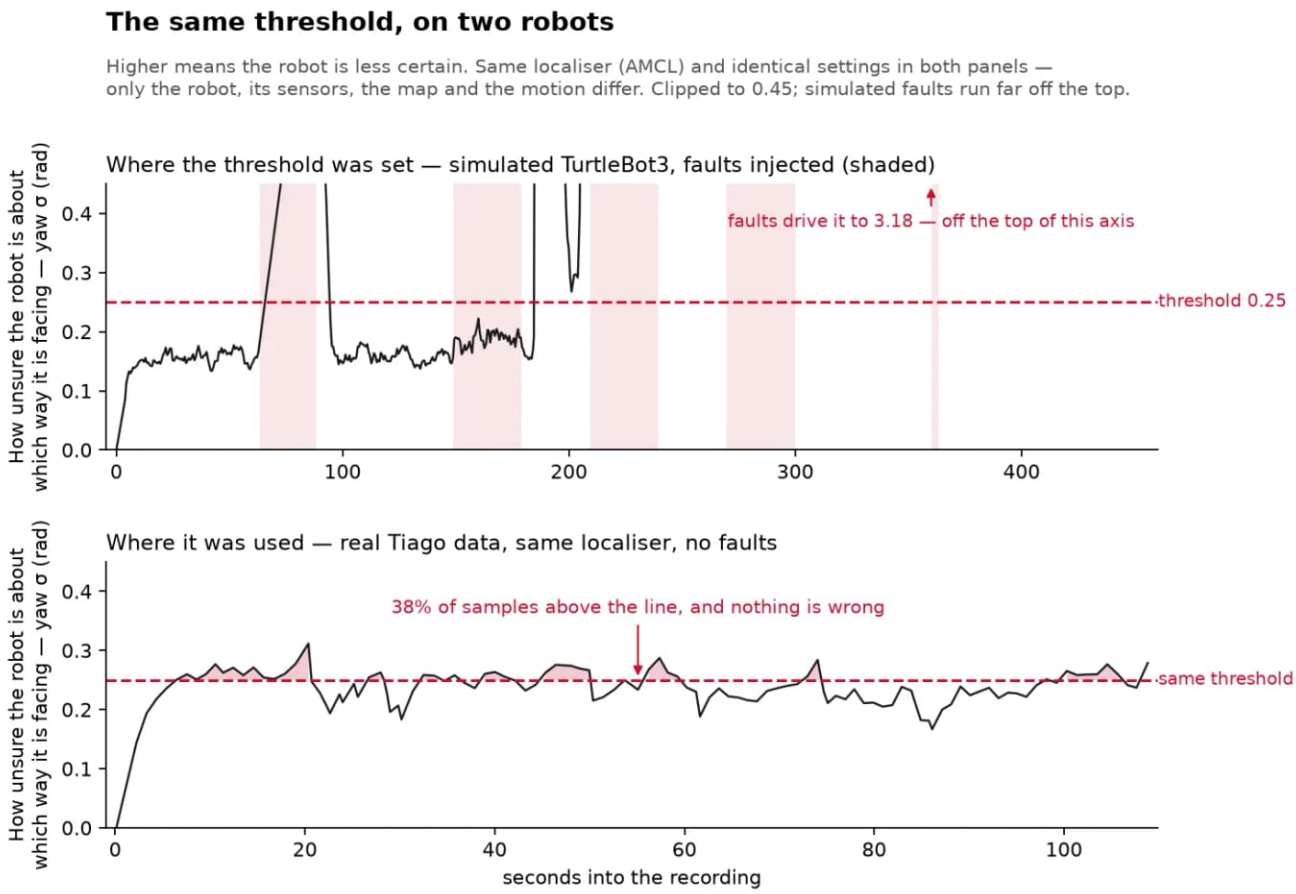
Four independent fault detectors for ROS 2/ROS 1 localization pipelines (sensor dropout, transform jumps, covariance spikes, pose divergence), tested against 108 minutes of real recordings from five robot platforms (Cartographer backpack rigs, a Tiago, a MiR100 AGV, a PR2, a handheld 3D rig), all public third-party benchmark data, not a live customer fleet. Every graded figure recomputes from a committed artifact with one script, `check_numbers.py`; the cross-platform flag rates recompute from the flag count and duration stated in their own row, bag linked. Clone the repo and run it.

WHY HARD

The same frozen thresholds did not transfer. The covariance threshold, set on a simulated TurtleBot3, sits inside a real Tiago's healthy yaw noise and fired five times on a recording with nothing wrong, graded wrong in the case log. A threshold is a property of the machine it was measured on, not of the failure. That is cross-platform transfer, not fleet calibration; calibrating to a live fleet's own robots is what an engagement builds.

WHAT HAPPENED

- 16 of 16 labelled laser gaps found, against labels the tool's author never wrote (the Cartographer dataset's own decade-old ground truth).
- Three predictions were committed before the ERL benchmark run. Two held, including that the laser-gap detector would show no elevation on the engineered failure runs: it fired zero times over 1,013 seconds. The prediction that the transform detector would not rise did not hold.
- Two case-log rows are graded "wrong" and published as such.
- One candidate dataset was rejected over its licence, not for a technical reason.



The same yaw-uncertainty threshold on two robots: set on a simulated TurtleBot3 where injected faults cross it, then applied to a real Tiago with no faults, where the signal rides the line for much of the recording.

ROS 2 · Log Analysis · Fault Detection · Localization · Python

theoalessandro.com/projects/ros2-localization-triage · github.com/thrmnn/ros2-localization-triage

MORE WORK

EPFL VITA Lab · 2022–23

Autonomous mobile robot navigation on a Segway Loomo

Research assistant, EPFL VITA Lab, under Alexandre Alahi · Lausanne · June 2022 to June 2023

Hidden	Where the people around a robot are and where they are heading, in a crowded indoor space.
Revealed	A modular ROS pipeline on a Segway Loomo: person detection and tracking, trajectory prediction, path planning and model predictive control.
Changed	Validated end to end on the physical robot among real pedestrians, not only in simulation; the code is public.



PROBLEM

Enable Segway Loomo robots to navigate crowded, dynamic indoor environments; most academic navigation systems never leave simulation.

BUILT

A modular ROS pipeline that runs on a server and drives the Loomo over a wireless socket link, one package per job:

- **Perception:** person detection (YOLOv5), a single-object tracker that holds on to the person being followed (Stark), and their 2D and 3D keypoints.
- **Estimation:** one node estimates the robot's state from its IMU and GPS; another builds a map and estimates the state from all its sensors.
- **Prediction:** where the followed person is heading.
- **Planning and control:** a collision-free path, followed with model predictive control.

It keeps the base of C. Conejo Bernal's earlier pipeline (2020–21); I redid its architecture and its perception block in 2022–23, continuing the VITA Lab research line. The perception models and the ROS 1 workspace are pinned to the 2023 stack; the modern successor of the perception is the real-time vision pipeline.

WHY HARD

Real-time performance across several computationally intensive perception modules running simultaneously, validated among actual pedestrians, not just in simulation.

WHAT HAPPENED

Validated end-to-end on physical robots (Segway Loomo, EPFL VITA Lab research platform); the code is public on GitHub (`github.com/thrmnn/ROS_Autonomous_Driving`).

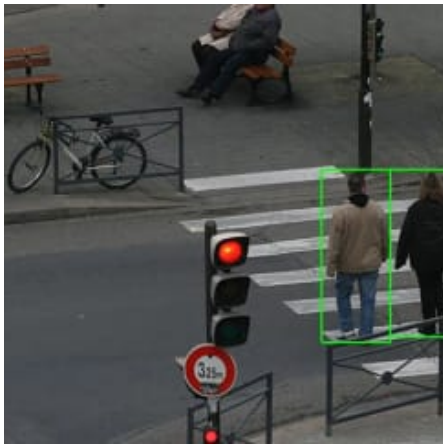
Path Planning · Autonomous Navigation · Multi-Object Tracking · ROS · C++ · OpenCV · Mobile Robotics

theoalessandro.com/projects/autonomous-mobile-robot · github.com/thrmnn/ROS_Autonomous_Driving

Open source · 2026

A real-time vision pipeline

Hidden	Four versions of the same detection and tracking work, built 2022 to 2023, sharing no interface and pinned to stacks that aged out.
Revealed	One modular stack behind narrow interfaces. Version 0.1 ships detection and tracking; re-identification and pose follow.
Changed	A module can be swapped without touching the rest, and every module reports its own latency. Open source, MIT licensed.



OVERVIEW

Across 2022–2023 I shipped four versions of "detection + tracking + ReID": single-person tracking on a Loomo robot, multi-person pose tracking, a ReID demo on Colab, and the perception module of a full ROS autonomy stack. Each solved a real problem in its context. None of them shared an interface; all four ran on dependency stacks that aged out.

`perception-pipeline` is the consolidated re-do against the 2026 stack. v0.1 ships detection and tracking (modern YOLO, ByteTrack); the roadmap below adds BoT-SORT / OC-SORT, OSNet-class ReID, MMPose-compatible 2D and 3D pose, and TensorRT export for Jetson-class hardware.

WHAT V0.1 SHIPS (JUNE 2026)

A runnable detector + tracker loop with the architecture the rest of the roadmap will plug into.

- **Narrow interfaces**: `Detector` and `Tracker` abstract base classes; every primitive lives behind one. Swap modules without touching the rest.
- **YOLO detection**: `ultralytics` wrapper, any checkpoint (`yolov8n` by default).
- **ByteTrack association**: via the `supervision` package; persistent track IDs across frames.
- **CLI demo**: `perception-demo --input video.mp4 --output annotated.mp4`. Latency summary printed on exit (per-module mean / p95, effective FPS).
- **Type contracts**: `Detections`, `Tracks`, `FrameResult` carry per-module latencies so the runtime can budget downstream stages.
- **MIT-licensed, pip-installable**: `pip install -e .` and you're running.

DESIGN PRINCIPLES

1. **Modules over monoliths.** Every primitive (detector, tracker, ReID, pose) is a stand-alone class behind a narrow interface; the pipeline is a composition.
2. **One config file per scenario.** No hand-edited launch scripts. YAML in, pipeline out. (Config-loading lands in v0.2.)
3. **Latency-budget-aware.** Every module reports measured latency; the runtime can downgrade or skip modules to hit a target frame budget.
4. **Platform-agnostic core, platform-specific shims.** ROS / standalone / SDK adapters live at the edge.

ROADMAP

- **v0.1**: Detection + tracking baseline (YOLO + ByteTrack), CLI demo, latency reporting. **Shipped June 2026.**
- **v0.2**: ReID hook (OSNet baseline), multi-person tracking, YAML pipeline config
- **v0.3**: 2D pose estimation (MMPose-compatible)
- **v0.4**: 3D pose lifting + temporal smoothing
- **v0.5**: Edge deployment (TensorRT export, Jetson Orin baseline, FP16 + INT8)
- **v0.6** (stretch): VLM-conditioned tracking ("track the person in the red jacket")

ANCESTORS

The historical record. These still run on their original dependency stacks:

- Perception-Pipeline (2022): single-person detection + tracking, method comparison
- **ReID** (2022): YOLO + ReID demo notebook · repo under maintenance
- **PostureTrack** (2023): modular pose tracking, single + multi-person · repo under maintenance
- ROS_Autonomous_Driving perception module (2023): same primitives wrapped in ROS for the Loomo robot

WHY OPEN

Public, MIT-licensed, modular: designed to be useful to whoever picks it up and an honest demonstration of how I think about real-time vision systems.

Object Detection · Multi-Object Tracking · YOLO · ByteTrack · PyTorch

theoalessandro.com/projects/perception-pipeline · github.com/thrmnn/perception-pipeline

IRI (CSIC-UPC, Barcelona) · 2023–24

Event cameras for high-speed drone state estimation

Visiting research fellow, IRI (CSIC-UPC), with Juan Andrade-Cetto · Barcelona · October 2023 to February 2024

Hidden	Where a drone is during aggressive flight, once frame cameras blur and standard visual-inertial odometry diverges.
Revealed	A PyTorch network that estimates 6-DOF pose from event-camera, RGB and IMU streams, trained on high-speed drone flights.
Changed	A pose estimator built for flight above 5 g, the regime where frame-based pipelines fail; the training framework is open source.

PROBLEM

Conventional frame-based cameras suffer motion blur at high angular and linear velocity, causing standard visual-inertial odometry (VIO) to diverge during aggressive quadrotor maneuvers exceeding 5g acceleration.

BUILT

A PyTorch network that estimates 6-DOF pose from three streams: an event camera (asynchronous per-pixel brightness changes, microsecond resolution), an RGB camera and an IMU.

- **Early fusion:** event and RGB frames are fused on a shared spatial tensor.
- **IMU encoder:** a WaveNet encoder reads the IMU stream over time.
- **Pose head:** a multi-modal head regresses the 6-DOF pose.

Trained on the UZH-FPV drone-racing dataset and the lab's own IRI-Borinot recordings (RGB, IMU and an event camera on a drone), with Juan Andrade-Cetto.

WHY HARD

Event cameras eliminate motion blur but require fundamentally different processing than standard frame-based VIO pipelines.

WHAT HAPPENED

The model targets maneuvers above 5g, the regime where conventional frame cameras and standard VIO diverge. The training framework is open source (EVIO); real-time onboard inference lives in a separate repository that is not yet open.

State Estimation · Visual-Inertial Odometry · Sensor Fusion · Event Cameras · Deep Learning · PyTorch · ROS · C++

theoalessandro.com/projects/event-cameras-drone · github.com/thrmnn/EVIO

A street-level sensor anyone can build

Research fellow in the Rio lab: projects and deployment, research meetings, talks

Hidden	Heat, humidity and fine particles at street level, where people actually walk and live.
Revealed	A sensor anyone can build: an Arduino board, a fine-particle sensor and GPS in a 3D-printed case, assembled in about 20 minutes, logging a line every 5 seconds.
Changed	Street-level air and heat can be mapped without a lab's equipment; in Maré, the measurements are being linked to urban form.

WHAT IT IS

Octopus is MIT Senseable City Lab's open-source sensor kit for street-level heat, humidity and fine particles, the step after City Scanner (2017, on garbage trucks in Cambridge, Massachusetts) and Flatburn (2023). An Arduino board, a fine-particle sensor and a GPS receiver sit in a 3D-printed case. It assembles in about 20 minutes and writes one line of data every 5 seconds to a microSD card, first on vehicles, then anywhere.

WHAT I DO

In the Rio lab I work on its projects and deployment, take part in the research meetings, and present the hardware (Casa Firjan summer school, October 2026). I am helping shape the new research line that links its measurements to urban form in Maré.

CREDITS

Octopus is led by Simone Mora and Fabio Duarte, with Carlo Ratti; electronics by FAE Technology.

Environmental sensing · Open hardware · Arduino · GPS · 3D printing theoalessandro.com/projects/octopus

Open source · 2026

A harness for AI agents

Hidden	Agent failures nobody sees: a tool call breaks, nothing traces it, and a user finds out first.
Revealed	A typed tool layer with one structured trace line per call, and a regression suite wired into CI.
Changed	A bad prompt change fails the build instead of reaching the user.

OVERVIEW

Agentic products hit the same walls: flaky tool calls, failures nobody can see, no evals, no safe way to ship a prompt change. A harness around the agent makes it behave like a production system: a typed tool layer, traces you can actually read, and an eval suite that catches regressions before users do.

WHAT THIS COVERS

- Typed, versioned tool layer (testable in isolation)
- An example keyword-search tool (`kb_search`) that demonstrates the eval harness on a retrieval-style task
- One structured trace line per tool call, small enough to grep
- Regression eval suite wired into CI

Status: v0.1, deliberately minimal. A reference implementation of the pattern, plain enough to copy into your own codebase rather than depend on.

WHERE IT STANDS

agent-harness is open source and deliberately minimal: a typed tool layer and a regression suite, not a framework.

AI Agents · Typed Tool Layer · Evals · Tracing · Agentic Systems

theoalessandro.com/projects/agent-harness · github.com/thrmnn/agent-harness